

Dem. Rep. Congo (Zaire)

 Formerly known as Belgian Congo and then as Zaire, this country was renamed Democratic Republic of the Congo in 1997 after the overthrow of the corrupt military government. The country consists of a plateau 1,200 m (3,900 ft) above sea-level, through which the River Congo flows. The land is fertile and rich in minerals, but spendthrift governments and civil war, including conflict with Rwanda in 1996–97, have kept it poor.



Creole woman selling diamonds

Farming

Dem. Rep. Congo has much potentially cultivable land. Sixty per cent of the population are subsistence farmers, producing palm oil, coffee, tea, rubber, cotton, fruit, vegetables, and rice. Here, on the border of volcanic Virunga National Park, the land is rich and fertile.



Cowrie shells are sewn on to decorate the mask.

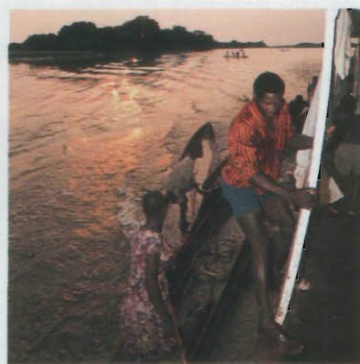
Mask

Among the many peoples of Dem. Rep. Congo are the Kuba, a small ethnic group who have lived there for many years. Their chief wears a hunting mask, known as a Mashambo mask, made of shells, beads, and raffia, to symbolize the power of the Great Spirit.



Mining

Copper ore, cobalt, and diamonds provide 85 per cent of national exports. Dem. Rep. Congo rates second in world diamond exports, with most mining activity in the Shaba province.



River ports

The River Congo and its tributaries give the country 11,500 km (7,000 miles) of navigable waterways. There are many river ports with boat-building and repair yards, craft shops, and lively markets that sell cassava, fruits, and fish, and delicacies such as monkey and snake meat. Traders take their produce to sell at river markets in dug-out canoes made by local craftsmen.

DEM. REP. CONGO FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Kinshasa

AREA 2,267,600 sq km (875,520 sq miles)

POPULATION 51,700,000

MAIN LANGUAGES French, English, Kiswahili, Lingala

MAJOR RELIGIONS Christian, traditional beliefs

CURRENCY Congolese franc



Ethnic strife

The present country boundaries in Central Africa date back to European colonialism, and cut across logical ethnic groupings. In some places there is actual ethnic warfare, for example that between the Hutus and the Tutsis of Rwanda and Burundi. For hundreds of years, Rwanda was dominated by the Tutsis, who ruled the Hutus. In 1959, the Hutus rebelled, and widespread fighting broke out. In the mid-1990s the violence escalated, resulting in 800,000 Hutu deaths and a massive refugee exodus into other countries.

Refugee camp, Tanzania

Sao Tome and Principe

 This tiny country, formed by the main volcanic islands of

Sao Tome and Principe, and four smaller islands, lies 200 km (120 miles) off the coast of Gabon.

Its mountains are covered with forests, and rich soil supports farms that grow cocoa beans and sugar-cane. Sea fishing has potential for development.



Pepper

The pepper plant's small, green berries redden as they ripen. Harvested straight away, the half-ripe berries are cleaned, dried in the sun, ground, and sifted to make ground black pepper.



Creole culture

Nobody lived on these islands until Portuguese explorers landed in 1470. The Portuguese peopled the islands with slaves from the mainland. Their mixed descendants created a culture called creole, but the creoles now number only ten per cent because more than 4,000 left the country at independence.

SAO TOME AND PRINCIPE FACTS

CAPITAL CITY São Tomé

AREA 960 sq km (371 sq miles)

POPULATION 159,900

MAIN LANGUAGE Portuguese

MAJOR RELIGION Christian

CURRENCY Dobra

Rwanda

 One of Africa's most densely populated countries, Rwanda has been made poor by ethnic strife that forced hundreds of thousands of people to flee to Dem. Rep. Congo for safety. Rwanda makes its money by exporting coffee, tea, and tin and tungsten ores. Most of its people just manage to feed themselves.



Volcanoes Park

The Parc des volcans is a scenic reserve dominated by volcanic mountains, two of which are active. The park is the last refuge of the mountain gorillas, which now number around 630.

RWANDA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Kigali

AREA 24,950 sq km (9633 sq miles)

POPULATION 7,700,000

MAIN LANGUAGES Kinyarwanda, French, Kiswahili

MAJOR RELIGIONS Christian, traditional beliefs

CURRENCY Franc

Burundi

 Like Rwanda, its neighbour, Burundi has been torn by conflict between the Tutsis and the Hutus, which has led to riots and thousands of deaths. Burundi has massive oil and nickel reserves beneath Lake Tanganyika, but lacks the funds to begin extraction. Most people are subsistence farmers.



Farming

Most farmers grow cassava and maize to feed their families. Some grow coffee, tea, cotton, and bananas for export. Overplanting fertile land is causing soil erosion.

BURUNDI FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Bujumbura

AREA 25,650 sq km (9903 sq miles)

POPULATION 6,700,000

MAIN LANGUAGES Kirundi, French, Swahili

MAJOR RELIGIONS Christian, traditional beliefs

CURRENCY Franc

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